

PIMPERED OUT PENGUIN

While they're not trying to replace your current Desktop, these Linux distributions come in really handy when you need a bunch of purpose-built software in one place

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It's extremely rare to have Windows preinstalled with all the software you need for, say, multimedia authoring. Then again, for a half-hour's work, you don't want to scour the Net hunting for software, so we turn our attention to Linux. The large number of open source tools available for it makes Linux a very good base to build a purpose-built operating system on. There are a lot if you look for them.

We've decided to take a look at distributions that have been created specifically for certain purposes and filling gaps left by most of the Desktop distros. They've been creating waves on the Internet for their functionality, though they aren't recommended for regular Desktop use. We have divided them into categories that should cover the majority of your computing needs outside of basic Desktop computing.

Most of these distributions are Live CDs, so you don't need to bother with installation—just boot off the CD or DVD to try them out. In the odd case that a distribution needs to be installed, you can first test it in a virtualised environment like VMWare or the free VirtualBox. Refer to the

30 Minute Expert to VirtualBox in our July issue for more. Once you're comfortable with the installation process and have decided on a distribution, go ahead and install it.

